Noncompliance by populists can take many forms, from ignoring rules and norms to skipping critical meetings. IOs rely on members to adhere to established regulations, with mechanisms in place to address violations. For example, states that break WTO rules or flout ICSID decisions may face dispute-resolution proceedings and even economic retaliation. Rather than back down, however, populists often escalate these conflicts, refusing to abide by rulings, thus further undermining the credibility of the IOs involved.

Populist noncompliance extends beyond the legal realm to the symbolic. Leaders may refuse to attend IO meetings or send lower-level representatives, signaling their disdain for these institutions. At organizations like the IMF and World Bank, board meetings are essential for approving programs, conducting surveillance, and shaping institutional agendas (Arias, Clark, and Kaya 2024). The absence of high-ranking officials diminishes the scope of collaboration and reduces IOs' ability to carry out their mandates (Frieden 2021).

Noncompliance is an appealing tactic for populists because it is easy to implement and offers a platform to broadcast their opposition to global elites. Yet this approach is not without costs. IOs often impose sanctions, initiate litigation, or cut off access to benefits for noncompliant states (Hafner-Burton 2008). At the IMF, for example, loans are disbursed in tranches, and further disbursements are withheld when states fail to meet conditionality requirements. This can lead to economic fallout and trigger domestic backlash from constituencies reliant on IO benefits.

IOs also face broader risks when powerful states refuse to comply. Noncompliance by influential members can create a ripple effect, encouraging other states to disregard rules and jeopardizing the IO's legitimacy and stability (Cialdini and Goldstein 2004; Carnegie and Carson 2020). The problem becomes especially acute when IOs rely on unanimous agreement to advance their agendas or when noncompliers hold pivotal positions within the organization. In such cases, IOs may find themselves paralyzed, unable to enforce rules or fulfill their missions effectively.